

Lab: Every Stitch Changes the Fabric

Objective

Explore crochet as action by executing different stitch policies, observing their effects on the fabric, practicing shaping actions, and performing a deliberate frogging exercise.

Materials

- Worsted weight yarn in two contrasting colors, approximately 30 yards of each
- Crochet hook, size H/8 (5.0mm)
- Pen and Action Log (template below)
- Ruler or tape measure
- Scissors

Action Log Template

Stitch Policy	Steps in Policy	Resulting Fabric Property	Height per Stitch	Notes

Steps

Part 1: Stitch Policies Side by Side (20 minutes)

1. With Color A, chain 31.
2. **Row 1 (Single Crochet):** Sc in 2nd ch from hook and in each of next 9 ch. (10 sc) Stop.
3. **Row 1 continued (Half Double Crochet):** Hdc in each of next 10 ch. (10 hdc) Stop.
4. **Row 1 continued (Double Crochet):** Dc in each of next 10 ch. (10 dc)
5. You now have three sections in one row, each using a different stitch policy. Measure the height of each section with your ruler. Record the measurements in your Action Log.
6. Feel each section. Notice how the three policies produce different densities, heights, and textures from the same yarn and hook.

Part 2: Insertion Variations (15 minutes)

1. Using Color A, chain 16. Work 2 rows of sc (15 sc per row) normally (under both loops).
2. **Row 3:** Sc in front loop only across. (15 FLO sc)
3. **Row 4:** Sc in back loop only across. (15 BLO sc)
4. **Row 5:** Sc under both loops (normal) across. (15 sc)
5. Look at your swatch from the side. You should see a visible ridge where Rows 3 and 4 created a textural change. Record in your log: same stitch type, different insertion point, different outcome. This is the same policy with a different sub-action producing a different world-state.

Part 3: Shaping Actions — Increases and Decreases (15 minutes)

1. Chain 2 with Color B. Work 6 sc in the second chain from the hook. Join with a sl st to the first sc. (6 sc in a ring)
2. **Round 2:** Ch 1, 2 sc in each st around. Join. (12 sc)
3. **Round 3:** Ch 1, *sc in next st, 2 sc in next st*, repeat around. Join. (18 sc)
4. You are making a flat circle. The increases (2 sc in one stitch) are shaping actions that control the geometry. Without them, the fabric would cup into a bowl. Record: how do increases function as actions that bring the fabric closer to the predicted flat shape?
5. If your circle is cupping or ruffling, your increases are too few or too many — this is prediction error in the shaping policy. Adjust if needed.

Part 4: Frogging as Corrective Action (10 minutes)

1. Look at your Color B circle. Deliberately frog Round 3 by pulling the yarn. Watch each stitch dissolve.
2. As you frog, notice: each stitch "undone" is an action in reverse. Internal states become external states. The Markov blanket retreats.
3. Now re-crochet Round 3. Notice how the second execution is faster and smoother — your motor policy has been refined by the first attempt.
4. Record: how did frogging and re-doing the round feel different from the first attempt? What changed in your action execution?

Part 5: Reflection and Discussion (10 minutes)

1. Review your Action Log. Which stitch policy produced the tallest stitches? The densest fabric? The most flexible?

Discussion Questions

- When you compared sc, hdc, and dc side by side, what did you learn about how different policies produce different outcomes from the same materials?
- The insertion variations (FLO, BLO, both loops) used the same stitch but changed one sub-action. How does this illustrate the modularity of motor policies?
- When shaping the circle, how did you know whether to increase more or less? What sensory feedback guided your shaping actions?
- After frogging and re-crocheting Round 3, was the second attempt better? What does this tell you about how action policies are refined through experience?

Wrap-Up

You have explored crochet as action: different stitch policies, insertion variations, shaping actions, and the corrective power of frogging. Keep your swatches for comparison in future modules.